

Why Google Will Falter In 2006

GOOGLE-BASHING IS IN. So are predictions for 2006. Here's a piece that says we won't think of Google as an "invincible behemoth." There are other tech predictions for the new year. Don't miss the full article—there are several hyperlinks you might want to explore.

Google will stumble in 2006.

I knew that would get your attention. Anything and everything Google is at the height of fashion right now. Every move that the company makes—like the advertising deal an obsessed press says it will announce with Time Warner's (Research) AOL unit tomorrow—gets a lot of attention in the press.

But what goes up must come down—especially in technology, the most volatile industry the world has ever seen. Yes, I love Google, but my first prediction is that a year from now we won't think that the search company is the invincible behemoth that we do now.

One reason for this a new concept known as "community-powered search." Yahoo is forging an early lead over Google in this fast-evolving technology with its acquisition last week of del.icio.us for a rumored \$35 million (the actual amount was undisclosed). Del.icio.us operates on principles similar to the popular MySpace. ...

Soon we will see a new form of results, like "What Others Liked," on all search engines. It's how Amazon tells its customers what others have bought, except that these search results involve information. In many cases, community-powered searches will let members find what they're

looking for more quickly than they would on a purely computerized type of web search, which Google does so superbly. Yahoo was already introducing community-based searches with My Web 2.0. Of course, Google is surely working on its own alternatives.

My second prediction is that Amazon will re-emerge as one of the web's most powerful properties, and provide increased competition for Google in 2006. Amazon has done a nice job grabbing more and more commerce dollars, but it has bigger ambitions, and a savvy tech strategy. ...

My third prediction is that telcos will become more powerful Internet service providers. ...

My fourth prediction is that Apple is likely to introduce a cell phone next year. ...

Here are the rest of my tech predictions for 2006:

TV viewing on cell phones will become routine.

AMD keeps kicking Intel's butt. AMD CEO Hector Ruiz told me this week that the company will announce its next big fabrication plant by next summer, earlier than most had expected. Another giant state-of-the-art factory (it only has one now) could help AMD better compete with Intel.

Microsoft's big software launches next year—the Vista OS and the next version of Office—won't generate much excitement.

Cisco may be the big-company investment of the year. This company's stock has flat-lined for 18 months, but every single trend that matters involves more bits flowing through more Internet-protocol pipes. As video online—the most data-intensive web application of all—becomes more pervasive, bit traffic will grow.

For the complete column, visit http://money.cnn.com/2005/12/19/technology/google_fortune/



Wikipedia Will Fail Within Five Years

WIKIPEDIA IS A hot topic of discussion right now, as we've indicated in our story in the *Enter* section of this issue. Here's Eric Goldman's take on the debate. (Goldman's research focuses on Internet law, technology and marketing practices. Recent articles of his have addressed warez trading, spam, search engine keywords and virtual worlds.)

This isn't just one article—the page mentions a wager Goldman had with one Mike Godwin, and includes Godwin's response. There are also pertinent comments by readers of Goldman's blog. Join the discussion!



Over the weekend I had dinner with Mike Godwin, one of the most significant influencers of the development of Cyberlaw and a longtime friend. Mike and I were discussing Wikipedia, the community-edited and -maintained encyclopedia. I like Wikipedia a lot and use it pretty frequently. However, as recent events have indicated, Wikipedia is far from perfect.

In particular, I remarked to Mike that Wikipedia inevitably will be overtaken by the gamers and the marketers to the point where it will lose all credibility. There are so many examples of community-driven communication tools that ultimately were taken over—USENET and the Open Directory Project are two that come top-of-mind—that I didn't imagine that my statement would be controversial or debatable. Instead, I was surprised when Mike disagreed with my assertion. Mike's view is that Wikipedia has shown remarkable resilience to attacks to date, and this is evidence that the system is more stable than I think it is.

Here's my thinking. As Wikipedia grows in traffic, outlinks from Wikipedia become more valuable—because of direct referrals and, perhaps more importantly, the PageRank that will flow from the link. Therefore, marketers will inevitably try to stuff links into Wikipedia. Because there are no barriers to editing Wikipedia, this is trivially easy for marketers to do. Eventually, marketers will build scripts to edit Wikipedia pages to insert links and conduct automated attacks on Wikipedia.

So long as the marketers' scripted/repeated activity is trivial in quantity, the self-policing community of Wikipedia will patiently delete those attacks—just like we delete spam from our in-boxes today. But over time, as the attacks become more determined and more automated, the Wikipedia community will become less enthusiastic about undoing the marketers' changes. At this point, one of two things will happen:

Wikipedia will have to change its open access nature.

Instead, Wikipedia will have to lock down lots of pages from being edited at all. Or Wikipedia will have to install some reputational management system to limit who has the right to post or edit content.

Alternatively, Wikipedia community members progressively will do less spam clean-up. This will lead to a gradual but ultimately irreversible downward spiral as more pages are taken over by marketers, decreasing the database's credibility. ...

Mike and I made a (wagerless) bet that on December 2, 2010, we will see where Wikipedia stands and decide the winner. If you have your own prediction on the fate of Wikipedia, please leave a comment.

To join the discussion, go to http://blog.ericgoldman.org/archives/2005/12/wikipedia_will.htm